# Machine-Checked Algorithmic Consequences of a $2^{o(n)}$ Algorithm for #$k$-SAT

Sebastian Senge
Independent Researcher

**Abstract**

In October 2026 two groups claimed algorithms for #$k$-SAT in time $2^{o(n)}$, which would refute the Exponential Time Hypothesis, and both formalized their algorithms in Lean. A refuted lower bound yields no algorithm by itself: every consequence needs a reduction to #SAT whose number of variables is linear in the relevant parameter. We give such reductions for seventeen problems and prove each resulting algorithm as a Lean 4 theorem about a single Turing machine, on top of Anthropic's formalization and with the standard axioms only. The new results are: the parity of the number of connected vertex sets of size $\ell$ that satisfy a given CNF, on graphs of any density; from it, with an isolation lemma for arbitrary sets, one-sided-error algorithms for Steiner tree and connected vertex cover on graphs of any density; the parity and a one-sided-error decision for connected dominating set on graphs of any density, whose clauses of domination have unbounded width, by running the clause-shortening tree of Anthropic's dominating-set algorithm inside the Cut & Count formula; #CNF-SAT of unbounded clause width with up to $n \cdot 2^{(\lg n)^{1/4}/(\lg\lg n)^2}$ clauses; counting $k$-colorings for all $k$ with $\lg k \le (\lg n)^{1/6-\theta}$; and the Max-SAT spectrum. We also formalize direct corollaries (homomorphisms into a target in the input, the density of states of the Potts model and the Tutte polynomial on the hyperbolas $(x-1)(y-1)=q$, the permanent of $\{-1,0,1\}$ matrices in $2^{\varepsilon m}\operatorname{poly}(n)$) and known consequences (#CNF-SAT of any width with linearly many clauses, the 0/1 permanent, Vertex Cover and Nonblocker in $2^{\varepsilon k}\operatorname{poly}(n)$). Our results on Hamiltonian cycles, the parity for $o(n\sqrt{\lg n}/\lg\lg n)$ edges and one-sided error for $O(n)$ edges, were obtained independently of Tulsyan's concurrent exact count, which supersedes them. All bounds hold for every $\varepsilon > 0$. We also give reference implementations of all reductions, tested against brute force and against the Lean definitions.

## 1 Introduction

The Exponential Time Hypothesis (ETH) of Impagliazzo and Paturi [16] states that 3-SAT on $n$ variables needs time $2^{\Omega(n)}$. Much of fine-grained complexity rests on it: tight lower bounds for coloring, Hamiltonian cycle and Max-Cut, the $2^{O(\sqrt{n})}$ barrier for planar problems, and most lower bounds for parameterized problems. In October 2026 two groups claimed that ETH is false.

- OpenAI [21] claims #$k$-SAT for every fixed $k$ in time

  $$(n+m)^{O_k(1)} \cdot 2^{O_k(n \lg\lg n/\sqrt{\lg n})},$$

  deterministic and in polynomial space, by contracting Boolean tensor networks with $s$ wires in time $2^{O(s/\sqrt{\log s})}$.

- Anthropic [1] claims #$k$-SAT with one machine for all $k$ in time

  $$2^{C\min(k^2 n \lg\lg n/\sqrt{\lg n},\, km/\sqrt{\lg m})}$$

  for an absolute constant $C$, by sum-product computations on the clause graph.

Both papers are unrefereed, and both come with Lean formalizations [2]. If the claims hold, ETH, SETH, #ETH, Gap-ETH and NSETH fall. The OV conjecture, the CNF-SAT hypothesis for poly($n$) clauses of unbounded width, the $k$-Clique conjecture and the Set Cover conjecture still stand. The algorithms are galactic: Anthropic reports no gain over $2^n$ below $n \approx 10^{10}$.

**Corollaries are not automatic.** A refuted lower bound gives no algorithm. To obtain a $2^{o(n)}$ algorithm for a problem $X$ from a $2^{o(n)}$ algorithm for #SAT, one needs a reduction from $X$ to #SAT with $o(n\sqrt{\lg n}/\lg\lg n)$ variables and, for a uniform bound, small clause width. Problems in size-constrained SNP reduce in this way [17]. Problems with global constraints (connectivity, orderings, large numbers) or dense pairwise interactions do not, at least not directly. This paper is about the second kind of problem: we find reductions that keep the number of variables linear in the parameter even though the natural encoding does not.

**Contributions.**

1. *Connectivity on graphs of any density* (Section 3). The parity of the number of connected vertex sets of size $\ell$ that satisfy a CNF (N2), and from it one-sided-error algorithms for Steiner tree and connected vertex cover (N2′), on graphs with any number of edges. The same for connected dominating sets (N7, N7′); the decision version also decides Max Leaf Spanning Tree. These are, to our knowledge, the first consequences of the claimed refutations for connectivity problems on dense graphs; the concurrent work on Hamiltonian cycles [25] needs $o(n\sqrt{\lg n})$ edges.

2. *Counting beyond the bounded-width case* (Section 4): #CNF-SAT of unbounded width with superlinearly many clauses (A1′), $k$-colorings for $k$ growing with $n$ (A2) and the Max-SAT spectrum (A4), with direct corollaries for homomorphisms, the Potts model and the Tutte polynomial, and permanents.

3. *Seventeen algorithms* (Table 1), each one a polynomial-time reduction to one of three counters from Anthropic's development, followed by a simple post-step. They are written out as pseudocode in Sections 3–6.

4. *Machine-checked statements.* Each algorithm is a Lean 4 theorem stating that one Turing machine (Mathlib's multi-stack model TM2, finite alphabets) halts on a given input with a given output within a given number of steps. The proofs build on Anthropic's development, which proves its $2^{o(n)}$ algorithm as a theorem; the results are therefore Lean theorems, not conditional statements. They use only the axioms `propext`, `Classical.choice` and `Quot.sound`.

5. *The isolation lemma of [6] for arbitrary sets*, formalized: sparse parity checks on $k$ coordinates isolate a point of any nonempty $S \subseteq \{0,1\}^M$ with probability $2^{-\delta M}$. The proof of [6] is oblivious to the formula [3, §9.3]; Tulsyan [25] formalizes the same lemma. Unlike Valiant–Vazirani hashing [26], it keeps the number of variables linear.

6. *Reference implementations* of all reductions in Python. They build the same formulas from the same input words as the Lean machines, and they are tested against brute force and against the Lean definitions.

**Techniques.** Three ideas recur. First, Anthropic's *sized* counter, which counts the solutions with exactly $s$ true variables, can be combined with complement bits $q = \neg p$: every complementary pair

Table 1: The results. Time bounds hold for every $\varepsilon > 0$ (resp. $\delta > 0$); $C$ and $n_0$ depend only on the stated parameters. $m$ is the number of edges, clauses or nonzero entries.

| | Problem and bound | Status |
|---|---|---|
| N2 | $\oplus$connected vertex sets of size $\ell$ satisfying a CNF, any density; $C2^{\delta n}$ | ours |
| N2′ | Steiner tree, connected vertex cover, one-sided error, any density; $C2^{\varepsilon n}$ | ours |
| N7 | $\oplus$connected dominating sets of size $\ell$, any density; $C2^{\delta n}$ | ours |
| N7′ | connected dominating set, one-sided error, any density; $C2^{\varepsilon n}$ | ours |
| A1 | #CNF-SAT, any width, $m \le Dn$; $C2^{\delta n}$ | known [7, 1] |
| A1′ | #CNF-SAT, any width, $m \le n\,2^{(\lg n)^{1/4}/(\lg\lg n)^2}$, one machine; $2^{\delta n}$ | ours |
| A2 | #$k$-colorings, all $k$ with $\lg k \le (\lg n)^{1/6-\theta}$, one machine; $2^{\varepsilon n}$ | ours (range of $k$) |
| N5 | #homomorphisms $G \to H$, $H$ in the input, $\lg\lvert V(H)\rvert \le (\lg n)^{1/6-\theta}$; $2^{\varepsilon n}$ | corollary |
| A4 | Max-SAT spectrum, width $r$, $m \le Dn$; $C2^{\delta n}$ | ours (spectrum) |
| N3 | Potts density of states, Tutte polynomial on $(x-1)(y-1) = q$, $m \le Dn$; $C2^{\delta n}$ | corollary |
| N6 | 0/1 permanent; $C(n+2)^C 2^{\varepsilon m}$ | known [21] |
| N6′ | $\{-1,0,1\}$ permanent; $C(n+2)^C 2^{\varepsilon m}$ | corollary |
| A5a | $\oplus$Hamiltonian cycles, degree $\le \Delta$; $2^{\varepsilon n}$ | superseded [25] |
| A5a′ | $\oplus$Hamiltonian cycles, $m = o(n\sqrt{\lg n}/\lg\lg n)$, one machine; $2^{\varepsilon n}$ | superseded [25] |
| A5b | Hamiltonian cycle, one-sided error, $m \le Dn$, one machine; $2^{\varepsilon n}$ | superseded [25] |
| A3 | Vertex Cover; $C(n+2)^C 2^{\varepsilon k}$ | known [17, 5] |
| A3′ | Nonblocker; $C(n+2)^C 2^{\varepsilon k}$ | known [15, 12] |

contributes exactly one true variable, so auxiliary variables leave the target size fixed. This is how side bits, isolation checks and parity chains enter a sized count (N2, N2′, N6′). Second, Cut & Count [10] turns connectivity into the parity of a count, and with a sized counter the number of edges no longer matters. Third, search trees (clause shortening for A1 and, inside a Cut & Count formula, for N7; degree branching for A3) reduce the parameter or the width before counting at the leaves.

**Honest labels.** Table 1 marks each result, after a literature search of 28 October 2026 (papers, preprints, blogs and repositories). A1, A3, A3′ and N6 are known consequences that we formalize. N3, N5 and N6′ are direct corollaries: the reduction is the obvious one. A5a, A5a′ and A5b are superseded by concurrent work [25]. The remaining results, N2, N2′, N7, N7′, A1′, the range of $k$ in A2 and the spectrum in A4, are ours: we did not find them, which does not mean that they are certainly new.

**Concurrent work.** Tulsyan [25], independently and also on top of Anthropic's Lean development, proves that one machine computes the number of Hamiltonian cycles of a graph with $n$ vertices and $m$ edges exactly and deterministically within $C2^{C(m+n)/\sqrt{\lg(n+2)}}$ steps, and within $C2^{\delta n}$ steps for $m \le Dn$. His method uses Anthropic's network machinery together with a matrix-tree identity, rather than the CNF counter. An exact count yields the parity and a deterministic decision, so his result supersedes A5a, A5a′ and A5b. Our versions were posted some hours earlier, on 27 October; we state them briefly in Section 5. We rebuilt both theorems from his repository on the same revision of Anthropic's development; they compile and use only the standard axioms, and his count is the same quantity as our $\mathrm{hc}(G)$ of Section 5. Since then (29 October) he has added a Lean-verified exact algorithm for TSP with polynomial weights on graphs with $m \le Dn$, and a written proof, not machine-checked, of exact counting in $2^{O(n\log\bar{d}/\sqrt{\lg n})}$ for average degree $\bar{d}$. He also sketches deterministic decision for Steiner tree, feedback vertex set, connected vertex cover and

connected dominating set on graphs with $m \le Dn$ and bounded degree, explicitly as a conjecture that is checked only numerically. He lists dominating set on dense graphs, and the exact counts of connected vertex covers and connected dominating sets, as not covered. The two refutation papers list corollaries of their own: OpenAI [21, Cor. 1.3] counts independent sets, $q$-colorings for fixed $q$ and perfect matchings (this covers N6), and Anthropic [1, Cor. 7] counts independent sets, cliques, vertex covers and dominating sets of each size, and $k$-colorings for fixed $k$, on graphs of any density.

**Related work.** The sparsification lemma [17] and the width–density duality of Calabro, Impagliazzo and Paturi [7] relate SAT variants with few variables; A1 is the latter duality combined with the claimed algorithm. For the maximum in A4, the equivalence of Max-$r$-SAT and Max-Cut with linearly many constraints with ETH is due to Jonsson, Lagerkvist, Schmidt and Uppman [18, Thm. 8]; Ganian, de Haan, Kanj and Szeider [15] show the same for Nonblocker and Dominating Set. For connectivity problems the direction we need was open: Impagliazzo, Paturi and Zane list Hamiltonian circuit only as SNP-hard [17], and Ganian et al. ask whether Feedback Vertex Set reduces to 3-CNF-SAT in this way [15]. Under ETH, connected dominating set has no $2^{o(n)}$ algorithm even on intersection graphs of convex objects in the plane [11]. For connected $G$ with $n \ge 3$ vertices, $n$ minus the connected domination number is the maximum number of leaves of a spanning tree [4]. Dell, Husfeldt, Marx, Taslaman and Wahlén [13] prove #ETH lower bounds for the permanent and the Tutte polynomial in terms of the number of edges or nonzero entries; N3, N6 and N6′ show that, given the claimed refutation, these problems become subexponential in the same parameter. Cut & Count [10] is the source of the parity reductions, and the isolation lemma of Calabro, Impagliazzo, Kabanets and Paturi [6] is the source of the isolation step in Section 3. Cai and Juedes [5] show that $2^{o(k)}\,\mathrm{poly}(n)$ for Vertex Cover refutes ETH; A3 is the converse, given the refutation. Cygan et al. [9] show that, under ETH, deciding $G \to H$ needs $|V(H)|^{\Omega(|V(G)|)}$ time in general. Our development uses Lean 4 [20] and Mathlib [19].

**Organization.** Section 2 describes the interface to Anthropic's development. Section 3 treats connected solutions on graphs of any density, Section 4 counting problems, Section 5 Hamiltonian cycles and Section 6 parameterized problems, each with algorithms, theorems and proof sketches. Section 7 describes the formalization and the reference implementation, and Section 8 discusses limitations.

## 2 Preliminaries and the interface

A literal is a pair $(i, b)$ and holds under $x \in \{0,1\}^N$ iff $x_i = b$. A CNF is a list of clauses; its width is the maximum clause length. We write $|x|$ for the number of true variables, $\#\psi$ for the number of satisfying assignments of $\psi$ on $N$ variables, and $\mathrm{cnt}_s(\psi)$ for the number of those with $|x| = s$. Logarithms lg are to base 2.

**Machines and encodings.** A machine is a TM2 machine of Mathlib with finite stack alphabets; its time is the number of steps until it halts with the stated output. Inputs are bit strings. A graph on $n$ vertices is $1^n0$ followed by its adjacency matrix, a relation on $[h]$ is its $h^2$ entries row by row, a number $t$ in unary is $1^t0$, and a CNF is $1^n0$ followed by its clauses, each literal written in $\lfloor \lg 2n \rfloor + 1$ bits.

**The counters.** We use three theorems of Anthropic's development as black boxes.

**Theorem 1** (SIZED, Anthropic)**.** *For every width $w$ and $\delta > 0$ there are a machine $\mathsf{SIZED}_w$, given as a stepped computation with polynomial-time steps, and a constant $c$, such that for all $N$, $s \le N$ and every CNF $\psi$ of width at most $w$ on $N$ variables, $\mathsf{SIZED}_w$ on $(1^N, s, \psi)$ returns $\mathrm{cnt}_s(\psi)$ within $c \cdot 2^{\delta N}$ steps of size at most $c(N + |\psi| + 2)^c$.*

**Theorem 2** (COUNT, Anthropic's Main Theorem)**.** *One machine COUNT and a constant $C$: for every $w \ge 1$ and every CNF $\psi$ of width $w$ with $m \ge 2$ clauses in which $N \ge 4$ variables occur, given in a compact code of length $L$, COUNT outputs $\#\psi$ within $2^{C \min(wm/\sqrt{\lg m},\ w^2 N \lg\lg N/\sqrt{\lg N})} + CL^C$ steps.*

**Theorem 3** (DOMCOUNT, Anthropic)**.** *For every $\delta > 0$ there are a stepped machine DOMCOUNT and $c$ that output the number of dominating sets of size $s$ of a graph on $n$ vertices within $c \cdot 2^{\delta n}$ steps.*

The number of clauses enters Theorem 1 only through the polynomial size of a step. Most of our reductions exploit this: their formulas have up to $n^2$ clauses, or as many as the input has edges, but only linearly many variables.

**Stepped computations and hosts.** Anthropic's machines are *stepped*: a computation is cut into polynomial-time steps, and a host theorem turns a stepped computation with $T$ steps of state size $S$ into a TM2 machine with $q(T+1)(|x| + S + 1)^q$ steps. A depth-first walk over the tree of a step function that sums a stepped computation over the leaves is again stepped (`walkSum`); its number of steps is bounded via the number of leaves. We add one host.

**Lemma 4** (FPT host, `tm_fpt`)**.** *Let a stepped computation run on inputs $x$ of size $n(x)$ with parameter $p(x)$ in at most $c\,2^{\delta p(x)}$ steps of state size $a(n+2)^e$. Then there are $C$ and one TM2 machine with finite alphabets that produces the same output within $\lfloor C(n+2)^C 2^{\delta p(x)} \rfloor$ steps.*

**The pattern.** Every algorithm below has the form

$$x \xrightarrow{\text{front end, poly time}} (N, s, \psi) \xrightarrow{\mathsf{SIZED}\text{ or }\mathsf{COUNT}} \text{count} \xrightarrow{\text{post-step}} \text{answer},$$

or a tree walk over such leaves. The front end is a polynomial-time function, proved so in Lean (`PolyT`), and it is joined to the counter by `Stepped.mapIn` and `Stepped.mapOut`. The proof obligations are always the same: the formula has the claimed width and number of variables, and its (sized) count is the quantity in the statement.

# 3 Connected solutions on graphs of any density

Cut & Count [10] replaces connectivity by the parity of a count. A vertex set $X$ has $2^{\mathrm{cc}(G[X])}$ maps $s : X \to \{0,1\}$ that are constant on the components of $G[X]$, and $2^{\mathrm{cc}(G[X])-1}$ is odd iff $G[X]$ is connected. The side bits add $n$ variables, and the edges of $G$ enter only as clauses. Theorem 1 is insensitive to the number of clauses, so the graph may be dense.

## 3.1 The parity of connected solutions (N2)

**Theorem 5** (`conn_parity_tm`, `cvc_parity_tm`)**.** *For every width $r$, exponent $D$ and $\delta > 0$, one machine, given a graph $G$ on $n$ vertices of any density, $1 \le \ell \le n$ and a CNF $\varphi$ on the vertices with clauses of at most $r$ literals and at most $(n+2)^D$ clauses, outputs the parity of the number of $X \subseteq V$ with $|X| = \ell$, $X \models \varphi$ and $G[X]$ connected, within $C2^{\delta n}$ steps.*

**Algorithm 1** Parity of connected solutions (N2). Lean: `Conn.connF`, `ConnTM.connM`.

**Input:** graph $G$ on $n$ vertices, $1 \le \ell \le n$, CNF $\varphi$ of width $r$ on the vertex bits

1: $x_v$: $v \in X$; $s_v = x_{n+v}$: the side of $v$; $\bar{s}_v = x_{2n+v}$
2: $\psi \leftarrow \varphi$, $\bar{s}_v = \neg s_v$, $x_v \vee \neg s_v$, and for each edge $uv$: $x_u \wedge x_v \to (s_u = s_v)$
3: $c \leftarrow \mathsf{SIZED}_{r+4}(3n,\ n+\ell,\ \psi)$ ▷ width $\le \max(r,4)$; $c = \sum_X 2^{\mathrm{cc}(G[X])}$
4: **return** $\lfloor c/2 \rfloor \bmod 2$

*Proof sketch.* Each pair $(s_v, \bar{s}_v)$ has exactly one true bit, so the solutions of size $n+\ell$ are the pairs $(X, s)$ with $|X| = \ell$, $X \models \varphi$ and $s$ constant on the components of $G[X]$ and 0 outside $X$ (`cnt_stepA`, `cnt_stepB`). There are $2^{\mathrm{cc}(G[X])}$ of them for each $X$, and $2^{\mathrm{cc}-1}$ is odd iff $G[X]$ is connected (`sig_parity`). The formula has $3n$ variables whatever the number of edges. □

With $\varphi$ the unit clauses $x_t$ for a terminal set $T$, the sets are the vertex sets of Steiner trees on $\ell$ vertices; with $\varphi = \{x_u \vee x_v : uv \in E\}$, the connected vertex covers of size $\ell$ (a separate machine on input $G, \ell$).

### 3.2 Isolation for arbitrary sets

**Theorem 6** (`isolation`; after [6])**.** *For every $\delta > 0$ there are $k, t$ such that for all $M \ge M_0(\delta)$ and every nonempty $S \subseteq \{0,1\}^M$, at least a $2^{-\delta M}$ fraction of the seeds leaves exactly one point of $S$. A seed consists of $3M+3$ parity checks on $k$ coordinates each (with right-hand sides), a number of them to use, and for every coordinate a value in $\{0, \dots, t-1\}$ and a bit; the coordinate is fixed to the bit when the value is 0.*

*Proof sketch.* One check on $k$ coordinates fails to separate two points at distance $d$ with probability $(1 + (1-d/M)^k)/2$ (`two_mul_card_rv`, by flipping one coefficient). Call $x \in S$ semi-isolated if no point of $S$ at distance $\ge \rho$ passes the same first $m$ checks. For the least $m$ with $2|S|q^m \le 1$, half of the check arrays make a given $x$ semi-isolated (`card_not_semi`); the semi-isolated points with the same check values lie in one Hamming ball (`card_fiber_le`). If the survivors lie within distance $< 2\rho$ of each other, fixing the coordinates where the two furthest differ leaves one point (`stepII`). The count `iso_count` is exact; `iso_real` takes $\rho = \lfloor M/a \rfloor + 1$ and $k = ab$, and the theorem picks $t$, $b$, $a$ against $\delta$. □

[6] state the lemma for solution sets of $k$-CNFs; its proof uses only $S \neq \emptyset$, and that is what we formalize. A check on $k$ coordinates is a chain of $k$ auxiliary variables $a_l = a_{l-1} \oplus (c_l \wedge x_{j_l})$ in clauses of width $\le 3$, and the chain bits are determined by the main variables. So isolating among the solutions of a CNF adds $O(Mk)$ variables, linear in $M$.

### 3.3 Steiner tree and connected vertex cover with one-sided error (N2′)

**Theorem 7** (`conn_randomized`)**.** *For every $r$, $D$, $\delta > 0$ and $\varepsilon > 0$ there are $k, t, n_0, C$ and one machine with the following property. For every graph $G$ on $n \ge n_0$ vertices of any density, $1 \le \ell \le n$, every CNF $\varphi$ as in Theorem 5 and every seed $\omega$, the machine halts on $(G, \ell, \omega, \varphi)$ within $C2^{\varepsilon n}$ steps with a bit* $\mathrm{out}(\omega)$*. If no vertex set of size $\ell$ satisfies $\varphi$ and induces a connected subgraph,* $\mathrm{out}(\omega) = 0$ *for every seed; if one does,* $\mathrm{out}(\omega) = 1$ *for at least a $2^{-\delta n}$ fraction of the seeds. In particular this decides with one-sided error whether $G$ has a Steiner tree on $\ell$ vertices and whether it has a connected vertex cover of size $\ell$.*

**Algorithm 2** Connected solutions with one-sided error (N2′). Lean: `ConnI.ciF`, `ConnITM.preR`.

**Input:** $G$, $\ell$, $\varphi$ as in Algorithm 1; a seed $\omega$ with $3n+3$ checks on the $n$ vertex bits

$\psi \leftarrow$ the formula of Algorithm 1 on $3n$ variables; $z = x_{3n}$, add $\neg z$
**for** each check $i < 3n+3$ with terms $(j_0, c_0), \ldots, (j_{k-1}, c_{k-1})$ **do**
  add $a_{i,l} = a_{i,l-1} \oplus (c_l \wedge x_{j_l})$ for $l < k$, where $a_{i,l} = x_{3n+1+ik+l}$ and $a_{i,-1} = z$
add $a_{i,k-1} =$ (right-hand side of check $i$) for the checks in use, and $x_j = \mathrm{bit}_j$ for the fixed coordinates
for every chain bit $a$, a complement bit $\bar{a} = \neg a$ ▷ keeps the target size fixed
$c \leftarrow \mathsf{SIZED}_{r+4}(3n+1+2(3n+3)k,\ n+\ell+(3n+3)k,\ \psi)$
**return** $\lfloor c/2 \rfloor \bmod 2$

**Algorithm 3** Parity of connected dominating sets (N7). Lean: `CdsTree.rootN`, `CdsTM.cdsM`.

**Input:** graph $G$ on $n$ vertices, $1 \le \ell \le n$

open $\leftarrow \{N[v] : v \in V\}$; closed $\leftarrow$ the clauses of Algorithm 1 for $\varphi = \emptyset$, on $3n$ variables
$c \leftarrow 0$
**for** each leaf (open′, closed′) of the tree of the shortening step with width $w$ **do**
  $c \leftarrow c + \mathsf{SIZED}_{w+4}(3n,\ n+\ell,$ open′ as positive clauses $\cup$ closed′$)$
**return** $\lfloor c/2 \rfloor \bmod 2$

*Proof sketch.* Algorithm 2. A chain bit and its complement hold exactly one true bit, so the solutions with $n+\ell+(3n+3)k$ true variables are those of Algorithm 1 with $n+\ell$ true variables whose vertex set passes the checks and the fixings (`stepC`–`stepE`), and half their number has the parity of the number of connected solutions of size $\ell$ that pass them (`ci_parity`). If there is no connected solution, this parity is 0 for every seed. If there is one, Theorem 6 applied to the set of connected solutions in $\{0,1\}^n$ leaves exactly one for a $2^{-\delta n}$ fraction of the seeds, and there the parity is 1 (`ci_decide`). The formula has $3n+1+2(3n+3)k = O(n)$ variables, whatever the number of edges. □

Running the machine on $R$ independent seeds and answering yes if some run outputs 1 never errs on a no-instance. On a yes-instance it errs on at most a fraction $e^{-R2^{-\delta n}}$ of the $R$-tuples of seeds, which is at most $e^{-2^{\delta n}}$ for $R \ge 2^{2\delta n}$ (`conn_amplified`).

### 3.4 Connected dominating set (N7, N7′)

A connected dominating set is a set $X$ with $G[X]$ connected such that every vertex is in $X$ or has a neighbour in $X$. Domination is the CNF $\varphi_{\mathrm{dom}} = \{\bigvee_{u \in N[v]} x_u : v \in V\}$, but its clauses have unbounded width, so Theorem 5 does not apply. Anthropic's algorithm for dominating sets [1, Cor. 7] (Theorem 3) shortens these clauses with a search tree after Calabro, Impagliazzo and Paturi [7]: in a clause with more than $w$ variables, let $H$ be its first $w$ variables; in the *light* child the clause is replaced by $\bigvee H$, in the *heavy* child the variables of $H$ are false and are deleted from all open clauses. We run this tree with the clauses of domination open and the clauses of Cut & Count closed.

**Theorem 8** (`cds_parity_tm`)**.** *For every $\delta > 0$, one machine, given a graph $G$ on $n$ vertices of any density and $1 \le \ell \le n$, outputs the parity of the number of connected dominating sets of $G$ with $\ell$ vertices, within $C2^{\delta n}$ steps.*

*Proof sketch.* Every assignment satisfies exactly one child of a node, so the sized counts of the leaves add up to that of the root (`cntS_step`, `sum_leaves`), which is the formula of Algorithm 1

**Algorithm 4** #CNF-SAT of any width (A1). Lean: `CnfTM.cnfM`.

**Input:** CNF $\varphi$ on $n$ variables, width bound $w$

root: variables $x_{2u}$ ("$u$ true"), $x_{2u+1}$ ("$u$ false"); closed clauses $x_{2u} \vee x_{2u+1}$, $\neg x_{2u} \vee \neg x_{2u+1}$; open clauses: each clause of $\varphi$ as a set of positive variables
$total \leftarrow 0$
**for** each node of the tree, depth first **do**
  **if** an open clause $K$ has more than $w$ variables; $H :=$ its first $w$ **then**
    light child: remove $K$ from the open clauses, add $\bigvee_{i \in H} x_i$ to the closed ones
    heavy child: add $\neg x_i$ for $i \in H$, delete $H$ from every open clause
  **else** $total \leftarrow total + \mathsf{SIZED}_w(2n,\, n,\, \text{open} \cup \text{closed})$
**return** *total*

with $\varphi = \varphi_{\text{dom}}$. A light step removes an open clause and a heavy step removes $w$ of the variables that occur in open clauses. Anthropic's invariant bounds these variables by the number of variables of the formula; ours (`InvC`) bounds them by $n$ while the formula has $3n$ variables and arbitrary closed clauses of width at most $w+4$. So a path has at most $n$ light and $n/w$ heavy steps, the tree has at most $\sum_{j \le 2n/w} \binom{2n}{j} \le 2^{\varepsilon n}$ leaves for $w$ large enough, and every leaf has width at most $w+4$ (`shortensN`). With $\varepsilon = \delta/4$ and $\mathsf{SIZED}_{w+4}$ at $\delta/12$ on $3n$ variables, the walk takes $C2^{\delta n/2}$ steps; Theorem 5's parity argument (`conn_parity`) gives the output. □

**Theorem 9** (`cds_randomized`)**.** *For every $\delta > 0$ and $\varepsilon > 0$ there are $k, t, n_0, C$ and one machine that, for every graph $G$ on $n \ge n_0$ vertices of any density, $1 \le \ell \le n$ and every seed $\omega$ as in Theorem 7, halts on $(G, \ell, \omega)$ within $C2^{\varepsilon n}$ steps with a bit* $\text{out}(\omega)$*. If $G$ has no connected dominating set of size $\ell$,* $\text{out}(\omega) = 0$ *for every seed; if it has one,* $\text{out}(\omega) = 1$ *for at least a $2^{-\delta n}$ fraction of the seeds.*

*Proof sketch.* The closed clauses at the root are now those of Algorithm 2 for $\varphi = \emptyset$, on $3n+1+2(3n+3)k$ variables; the open ones are still the $n$ clauses of domination on the vertex bits, so the tree and its bound are those of Theorem 8. The sum over the leaves is the count of Algorithm 2 for $\varphi = \varphi_{\text{dom}}$, and `ci_decide` gives the one-sided error. Amplification is as for N2′ (`cds_amplified`). □

A superset of a connected dominating set is again one, so a connected dominating set of size $\ell$ exists iff one of size at most $\ell$ does. For connected $G$ with $n \ge 3$, this holds iff $G$ has a spanning tree with at least $n - \ell$ leaves [4]. Theorem 9 therefore also decides Max Leaf Spanning Tree with one-sided error in $C2^{\varepsilon n}$; these two facts are not formalized. The proof of Theorem 8 uses only that the open clauses are at most $n$ positive clauses without repeated variables on the vertex bits; open neighbourhoods, for connected total domination, are another example.

# 4 Counting

## 4.1 CNF of any width (A1, A1′)

**Theorem 10** (`cnf_counts`)**.** *For every $D$ and $\delta > 0$, one machine counts the satisfying assignments of every CNF with $n$ variables and at most $Dn$ clauses, of any width and with no literal repeated within a clause, within $C2^{\delta n}$ steps.*

*Proof sketch.* Algorithm 4. Since $|x| = n$ forces exactly one of $x_{2u}, x_{2u+1}$, the solutions of size $n$ at the root are the assignments of $\varphi$. A node's count is the sum of its children's (either some variable of

**Algorithm 5** Homomorphisms $G \to H$ (N5; A2 is $H = K_k$). Lean: `Hom.homB`, `colB`.

**Input:** graph $G$ on $n$ vertices, relation $H$ on $[h]$

1: $b \leftarrow \lceil \lg h \rceil$; the bits $x_{vb}, \dots, x_{vb+b-1}$ spell the image of $v$
2: for each $v$ and each code $h \le c < 2^b$: clause "the bits of $v$ do not spell $c$"
3: for each edge $uv$ (both orders) and each $(a, c)$ with $\neg H(a, c)$: clause "not ($u$ spells $a$ and $v$ spells $c$)"
4: tautologies $x_i \vee \neg x_i$ for $i < nb$; unit clauses $x_{nb}, \dots, x_{nb+3}$
5: **return** $\mathsf{COUNT}(nb + 4, \psi)$

$H$ is true, or all are false), and every leaf has width $\le w$. The tree is Anthropic's clause-shortening tree from their Dominating Set corollary; we replace its invariant, which needs at most $n$ clauses, by one for $Dn$ clauses. The tree has at most $2^{(2/w)\lg(ew(D+2))n}$ leaves, which is $2^{\delta n/2}$ for $w$ large. □

**Theorem 11** (`cnf_grow`)**.** *One machine: for every $\delta > 0$ there is $n_0$ such that on every CNF with $n \ge n_0$ variables and at most $n \cdot 2^{(\lg n)^{1/4}/(\lg\lg n)^2}$ clauses of any width, with no literal repeated within a clause, it outputs the number of satisfying assignments within $2^{\delta n}$ steps.*

*Proof sketch.* Algorithm 4 with the width read off the node: for $N$ variables, $\ell = \lfloor \lg N \rfloor$ and $L = \lfloor \lg \ell \rfloor$, take $w = 2^{\lfloor L/4 \rfloor - \lfloor \lg L \rfloor} + 1 \approx \ell^{1/4}/L$, and count each leaf with $\mathsf{COUNT}$. Its exponent $Cw^2 N \lg\lg N/\sqrt{\lg N}$ is at most $32CN/L = o(n)$, since $w^2L^2 \le 16\sqrt{\ell}$. For $D \le 2^s + 1$ with $s = (\lg n)^{1/4}/(\lg\lg n)^2$, so that $s \le 4w/(L-1)$, the coefficient $(2/w)\lg(ew(D+2))$ of the tree bound is at most $(8 + 6\sqrt{w})/w + 8/(L-1) \to 0$. □

## 4.2 Colorings and homomorphisms (A2, N5)

Let $H$ be a relation on $[h] = \{0, \dots, h-1\}$ (loops allowed, not necessarily symmetric) and $\hom(G, H)$ the number of maps $f : V(G) \to [h]$ with $H(f(u), f(v))$ for every edge $uv$. For $H = K_k$ these are the proper $k$-colorings.

**Theorem 12** (`colorings_subexp`, `hom_subexp`, `hom_subexp_graph`)**.** *One machine, given $h$ in unary, the matrix of $H$ and an $n$-vertex graph $G$, outputs $\hom(G, H)$ within $2^{\varepsilon n}$ steps, for every $\varepsilon > 0$, $0 < \theta < 1/6$, $n \ge n_0(\theta, \varepsilon)$ and all $h \ge 2$ with $\lg h \le (\lg n)^{1/6-\theta}$. For a simple graph $H$ the output is the number of Mathlib homomorphisms $G \to_g H$; for $H = K_k$ it is the number of proper $k$-colorings.*

*Proof sketch.* The satisfying assignments of the formula of Algorithm 5 are exactly the homomorphisms (`cntN_homB`). It has $N = nb + 4$ variables and width $2b$, so the exponent of Theorem 2 is $C \cdot 4b^2 \cdot N \lg\lg N/\sqrt{\lg N} = O(n(\lg n)^{-2\theta})$ for $b \le 2(\lg n)^{1/6-\theta}$, because $b^3 \le 8(\lg n)^{1/2-3\theta}$ and $\lg\lg N \le (\lg N)^\theta/(\theta \ln 2)$. The at most $n^2h^2 + O(nh)$ clauses only enter the polynomial factor. □

Taking $h = 2$ and $H$ an edge with a loop at one end counts the independent sets of $G$ in Mathlib's sense, for graphs of any density (`numHom_hInd`, `indep_subexp`).

## 4.3 The Max-SAT spectrum (A4) and the Potts model (N3)

**Theorem 13** (`maxsat_spectrum`)**.** *For every width $r$, density $D$ and $\delta > 0$, one machine outputs, given a CNF $\varphi$ with $m \le Dn$ clauses of at most $r$ literals and $t \le m$, the number of assignments that satisfy exactly $t$ clauses, within $C2^{\delta n}$ steps.*

**Algorithm 6** The $\{-1,0,1\}$ permanent (N6′; N6 returns $\mathsf{SIZED}_2(m,n,\psi)$ after line 2). Lean: `Perm.permF`, `SPerm.chainF`, `SPermTM.spermM`.

**Input:** $A, S \in \{0,1\}^{n\times n}$: $M_{ij} = 0$ if $\neg A_{ij}$, $-1$ if $A_{ij} \wedge S_{ij}$, 1 otherwise

1: $e_0, \dots, e_{m-1} \leftarrow$ the entries with $A_{ij} = 1$, row by row; one variable $x_t$ each; **if** $m < n$ **return** 0
2: $\psi \leftarrow \{\neg x_s \vee \neg x_t : s < t,\ e_s, e_t$ share a row or a column$\}$ ▷ width 2
3: $g_0, \dots, g_{r-1} \leftarrow$ the indices $t$ with $S$ at $e_t$
4: **for** $b \in \{0,1\}$ **do**
5: $\quad \psi_b \leftarrow \psi \cup \{\neg z\} \cup \{p_k = p_{k-1} \oplus x_{g_k},\ q_k = \neg p_k : k < r\} \cup \{p_{r-1} = b\}$
$\quad$ where $z = x_m$, $p_{-1} = z$, $p_k = x_{m+1+k}$, $q_k = x_{m+1+r+k}$ ▷ width 3
6: $\quad N_b \leftarrow \mathsf{SIZED}_3(m+1+2r,\ n+r,\ \psi_b)$
7: **return** $N_0 - N_1$

*Proof sketch.* Use the $2n$ variables of A1 and one variable $y_j = x_{2n+j}$ per clause $K_j$, with clauses $y_j \leftrightarrow K_j$ (width $r+1$), the literal $(u,b)$ read on $x_{2u}$. A solution with $n+t$ true variables is an assignment of $\varphi$ together with the indicator of its $t$ satisfied clauses (`cntS_specF`). Return $\mathsf{SIZED}_{r+2}(2n+m,\ n+t,\ \psi)$. □

For graphs with $O(n)$ edges, the Max-Cut spectrum and the density of states of the $\pm1$ Ising model follow from N3 below with $q = 2$ (`maxcut_spectrum`, `ising_spectrum`). For a graph $G$ and $q$ colors let $N_j$ be the number of colorings $\sigma : V \to [q]$ with exactly $j$ monochromatic edges, $k(A)$ the number of components of $(V, A)$, and $T(G;x,y) = \sum_{A\subseteq E}(x-1)^{k(A)-k(E)}(y-1)^{|A|+k(A)-n}$.

**Theorem 14** (`potts_spectrum`, `potts_fk`, `tutte_hyperbola`, `tutte_tm`)**.** *For every $q \geq 1$, $D$ and $\delta > 0$, one machine outputs $N_j$, given $G$ with $m \leq Dn$ edges and $j \leq m$, within $C2^{\delta n}$ steps. In every commutative ring $\sum_j N_j(1+v)^j = \sum_{A\subseteq E} q^{k(A)}v^{|A|}$, and in every field, if $(x-1)(y-1) = q$ and $x, y \neq 1$, then $(x-1)^{k(E)}(y-1)^n T(G;x,y) = \sum_j N_j y^j$.*

*Proof sketch.* Variables $x_{vq+c}$ ("$v$ has color $c$") and $y_i = x_{nq+i}$ ("edge $i$ is monochromatic"), $nq+m$ in all. Clauses: each vertex has at least one color (width $q$) and at most one (width 2); for each edge $(a,b)$ and color $c$, $x_{aq+c} \wedge x_{bq+c} \to y_i$ and $y_i \wedge x_{aq+c} \to x_{bq+c}$. The solutions with $n+j$ true variables are the colorings with $j$ monochromatic edges (`cnt_pottsF`); return $\mathsf{SIZED}_{q+3}(nq+m,\ n+j,\ \psi)$. The identities are the Fortuin–Kasteleyn expansion [14]: expand $\prod_e(1 + v[e \text{ mono}])$ over $A \subseteq E$; the colorings constant on the components of $(V, A)$ are $q^{k(A)}$ many (`card_const`). □

For $q = 2$, the colorings with $j$ monochromatic edges are the vertex sets whose cut has $m - j$ edges (`pottsSpec_two`), and the spin configurations with $\sum_{uv\in E} s_u s_v = 2j - m$ (`ising_spectrum`). $N_0$ is the number of proper $q$-colorings in Mathlib's sense (`pottsSpec_zero`). It is the chromatic polynomial at $q$, and $N_0 = (-q)^{k(E)}(-1)^n T(G; 1-q, 0)$ (`chromatic_tutte`). At the point $(0, 1-q)$ the theorem gives $T(G; 0, 1-q)$ (`flow_tutte`), which by Tutte's theorem [24] is $(-1)^{m-n+k(E)}$ times the number of nowhere-zero $\mathbb{Z}_q$-flows. Under #ETH, [13] prove lower bounds of the form $2^{\Omega(n/\operatorname{polylog} n)}$ for such evaluations on sparse graphs.

### 4.4 The permanent (N6, N6′)

**Theorem 15** (`perm_fpt`, `sperm_fpt`, `permanent_signed`)**.** *For every $\varepsilon > 0$ there are $C$ and one machine that, given a bit $b$, $n$ in unary and $A, S \in \{0,1\}^{n\times n}$, outputs $N_b = \#\{\sigma \in S_n : \forall i\ A_{\sigma(i),i} = 1,\ |\{i : S_{\sigma(i),i} = 1\}| \equiv b \pmod 2\}$ within $C(n+2)^C 2^{\varepsilon m}$ steps, where $m$ is the number of ones of $A$. The permanent of $M$ (Mathlib's `Matrix.permanent` over $\mathbb{Z}$) equals $N_0 - N_1$. For $S = 0$ a separate machine outputs the permanent of the 0/1 matrix $A$ directly, in the same time.*

**Algorithm 7** Parity of the number of Hamiltonian cycles (A5a, A5a′). Lean: `Ham.hcF`, `HamS.hcS`.

**Input:** graph $G$ on $n$ vertices with edges $e_0, \dots, e_{m-1}$

1: $x_i$: edge $e_i$ is chosen; $s_v = x_{m+v}$: the side of $v$

2: for each $v$: exactly two chosen edges at $v$

A5a: $\neg x_a \vee \neg x_b \vee \neg x_c$ for distinct edges at $v$, and "at least two" (width $\deg v$)

A5a′: a sequential counter along the edges at $v$, two bits per (edge, end), width 3

3: for each edge $e_i = ab$: $x_i \to (s_a = s_b)$; $\neg s_0$; $x_i \vee \neg x_i$ for every variable

4: **return** $\mathsf{COUNT}(N, \psi) \bmod 2$ ▷ $N = m + n$ (A5a), $N = 5m + n + 2$ (A5a′)

*Proof sketch.* An assignment of $\psi$ with exactly $n$ true variables chooses $n$ ones of $A$ with no two in a row or a column, i.e. a permutation $\sigma$ with $A_{\sigma(i),i} = 1$ for all $i$; the map is a bijection (`cntS_permF`), and these $\sigma$ are the nonzero terms of the permanent of the 0/1 matrix (`permanent_eq`). In $\psi_b$ the chain bits are determined by the choice (`chain_det`), $p_k$ is the parity of the first $k+1$ entries $-1$ that are chosen (`chainVal_eq`), and every pair $(p_k, q_k)$ has exactly one true bit. So the solutions of size $n + r$ are the permutations of parity $b$ (`cnt_sperm`). The term of $\sigma$ in the permanent of $M$ is $(-1)^{j(\sigma)}$, where $j(\sigma)$ is the number of entries $-1$ on $\sigma$ (`permanent_signed`). The formula has $m + 1 + 2r \le 3m + 1$ variables, so $\mathsf{SIZED}_3$ at $\delta = \varepsilon/3$ takes $c\, 2^{\varepsilon/3} 2^{\varepsilon m}$ steps, and Lemma 4 gives the machine. □

Under #ETH the permanent of $\{-1, 0, 1\}$ matrices has no $\exp(o(m))$ algorithm, and that of 0/1 matrices none in $\exp(o(m/\log m))$ [13, Thm. 1.3]. Ryser's formula [23] takes $O(2^n n)$ time.

## 5 Hamiltonian cycles

Let $\mathrm{hc}(G)$ be the number of connected spanning subgraphs of $G$ with all degrees 2. In Section 7 we prove that it is the number of Hamiltonian cycles in Mathlib's sense. Tulsyan [25] computes $\mathrm{hc}(G)$ exactly and deterministically, which supersedes the results of this section; we obtained them independently and state them briefly. The encoding is that of Section 3 with edge bits in place of vertex bits.

**Theorem 16** (`hc_parity_subexp`, `hc_parity_little_o`)**.**
*For each $\Delta$, one machine decides whether a graph with all degrees at most $\Delta$ has an odd number of Hamiltonian cycles within $2^{\varepsilon n}$ steps for $n \ge n_0(\varepsilon)$. One machine decides it for all graphs of any degree with at most $n\, g(n)$ edges, within $2^{\varepsilon n}$ steps for $n \ge n_0(g, \varepsilon)$, for every $\varepsilon > 0$ and every $g$ with $g(n)\, r(n) \to 0$, where $r(n) = \lg\lg(n+4)/\sqrt{\lg(n+4)}$. That is, $m = o(n\sqrt{\lg n}/\lg\lg n)$ edges suffice. This includes $m \le n(\lg n)^{1/2-\theta}$ (`hc_parity_sparse`) and every degree bound $\Delta$ (`hc_parity_bounded`).*

*Proof sketch.* Algorithm 7 is Cut & Count [10]. A chosen 2-factor with $c$ cycles has $2^{c-1}$ side maps with $s_0 = 0$, which is odd iff $c = 1$ (`parity_sides`: flip the sides on a cycle that avoids vertex 0), so $\#\psi \equiv \mathrm{hc}(G) \pmod 2$ (`hc_parity`). The sequential counter has the same solutions on the edge and side bits (`cntN_hcS`). For A5a′ the bound of Theorem 2 with width 3 and $N = 5m + n + 2$ variables is $c\, 2^{9cN\, r(N)}$, with $r$ as in the theorem. Since $m \le n^2$, we have $N + 4 \le (n+4)^3$ and hence $r(N) \le 3r(n)$ (`rate_three`). So the exponent is at most $27c(5n\, g(n) + n + 2)\, r(n)$, which is below $\varepsilon n/2$ for large $n$ because $g(n)r(n) \to 0$ and $r(n) \to 0$ (`bound0_le`). □

**Theorem 17** (`ham_randomized`)**.** *There is one machine such that for every $D$, $\delta > 0$ and $\varepsilon > 0$ there are $k, t, n_0$ with the following property. For every graph $G$ with $n \ge n_0$ vertices and at most*

**Algorithm 8** Vertex Cover (A3). Lean: `Vc.stepV`, `Vc.leafV`, `VcTM.vcM`.

**Input:** graph $G$, budget $k$; a degree $d$ chosen from $\varepsilon$

*total* $\leftarrow 0$
**for** each node $(k', E')$ of the tree from $(k, E(G))$, depth first **do**
  **if** $k' > 0$ and an end $v$ of an edge of $E'$ has $\geq d$ neighbours $N(v)$ **then**
    children: $(k' - 1,\ E' \setminus \delta(v))$ and $(k' - |N(v)|,\ E' \setminus \delta(N[v]))$
  **else**
    $V' \leftarrow$ the ends of the edges of $E'$
    **if** $|V'| \leq k'd$ **then** $total \leftarrow total + \mathsf{SIZED}_2(|V'|, \min(k', |V'|), \{x_u \vee x_v : uv \in E'\})$
**return** $[total > 0]$

**Algorithm 9** Nonblocker (A3′). Lean: `NbTM.preN`, `NbTM.nbM`.

**Input:** graph $G$ on $n$ vertices, $k \leq n$

$J \leftarrow$ the vertices with a neighbour; $n' \leftarrow |J|$
**if** $2k \leq n'$ **then return** yes ▷ Ore: $G[J]$ has a dominating set of size $\leq n'/2$
**else if** $n' < k$ **then return** no
**else return** $[\mathsf{DOMCOUNT}(G[J],\ n' - k) > 0]$ ▷ $n' < 2k$ vertices

*Dn edges and every seed $\omega$ of checks on the $m$ edge bits, the machine halts on $G$ and $\omega$ within $2^{\varepsilon n}$ steps with a bit* $\mathrm{out}(\omega)$. *If $G$ has no Hamiltonian cycle,* $\mathrm{out}(\omega) = 0$ *for every seed; if it has one,* $\mathrm{out}(\omega) = 1$ *for at least a $2^{-\delta n}$ fraction of the seeds.*

*Proof sketch.* Add the checks and fixings of $\omega$ on the edge bits to the formula of A5a′, as in Algorithm 2 but without complement bits, since $\mathsf{COUNT}$ does not fix the number of true variables. The count is $\equiv$ the number of Hamiltonian cycles that pass the checks and fixings (`iso_parity`), and Theorem 6 applied to the set of Hamiltonian cycles in $\{0,1\}^m$ leaves exactly one for a $2^{-\delta m}$ fraction of the seeds (`iso_decide`). The machine decodes $k$, the checks and the fixings from the input (`decode_seedCode`), so one machine serves every $\delta$. The formula has $5m+n+2+(3m+3)k = O(n)$ variables. Repetition over $R$ seeds amplifies as in Section 3 (`ham_amplified`). □

## 6 Parameterized by the solution size

**Theorem 18** (`vc_fpt`)**.** *For every $\varepsilon > 0$, one machine, given a graph $G$ on $n$ vertices (of any density) and $k \leq n$, decides whether $G$ has a vertex cover of at most $k$ vertices within $C(n+2)^C 2^{\varepsilon k}$ steps.*

*Proof sketch.* Algorithm 8; no kernel is used. A node has a cover within budget iff one child has (`good_step`), since a cover misses $v$ only if it contains $N(v)$. Along a path the budget drops by 1 or by at least $d$, so by Anthropic's tree bound there are at most $\sum_{j \leq (k+d)/d} \binom{k+d}{j} \leq 2^{\varepsilon'(k+d)}$ leaves (`leaves_le`). At a leaf all degrees are below $d$, so a cover of size $\leq k'$ leaves at most $k'd$ vertices on the edges (`card_V_le`), and $\mathsf{SIZED}_2$ decides the leaf in $2^{\delta kd}$ steps (`cnt_leafV_pos`); $\delta = \varepsilon/(4d)$ makes this $2^{\varepsilon k/4}$. Lemma 4 turns the walk into one machine. □

The best known algorithm for Vertex Cover runs in $O(1.2738^k + kn)$ time [8]. The Nonblocker problem asks for $k$ vertices whose complement dominates, i.e. for a dominating set of at most $n - k$ vertices.

**Theorem 19** (`nb_fpt`). *For every $\varepsilon > 0$, one machine, given $G$ on $n$ vertices and $k \le n$, decides whether $G$ has a dominating set of at most $n - k$ vertices within $C(n+2)^C 2^{\varepsilon k}$ steps.*

*Proof sketch.* Isolated vertices lie in every dominating set, so the question is the same for $G[J]$ and the bound $n' - k$ (`nb_iff`). $G[J]$ has no isolated vertex, so by Ore's theorem [22] it has a dominating set of at most $n'/2$ vertices: the complement of a minimum dominating set dominates (`ore`). Supersets of dominating sets dominate, so in the remaining case a set of size exactly $n' - k$ exists iff one of size at most $n'-k$ does (`nb_answer`). DOMCOUNT at $\delta = \varepsilon/2$ runs in $c\,2^{(\varepsilon/2)n'} \le c\,2^{\varepsilon k}$ steps. □

This is the linear kernel of [12] in its simplest form, with the claimed refutation as the exponential part.

# 7 Formalization and reference implementation

**The Lean development.** The development consists of 41 Lean files with about 13,000 lines on top of Anthropic's development (pinned to a fixed revision) and Mathlib. A check file prints the axioms of 69 theorems, the main theorems and the lemmas cited in the proof sketches; each depends on `propext`, `Classical.choice` and `Quot.sound` only, and there is no `sorry`. Every main theorem quantifies over the machine existentially and states its finite alphabets, its output (`Wrap.Outputs`) and its time bound explicitly. The polynomial-time front ends are verified with Anthropic's `PolyT` combinators and `fun_prop`. Most of the proof effort goes into two kinds of lemmas: shape bounds (width, number of variables and clauses of the formula, as functions of the input) and count identities (the sized count equals the intended quantity), which are proved as explicit bijections of finite sets.

**Checks against Mathlib.** Lean cannot check that a definition means what is intended, so where Mathlib has an independent definition we prove agreement. The number of Hamiltonian cycles $\mathrm{hc}(G)$ is positive iff $G$ satisfies Mathlib's `SimpleGraph.IsHamiltonian` (for $n \neq 1$), and it equals the number of edge sets of walks with Mathlib's `IsHamiltonianCycle` (`numHamCycles_pos_iff`, `numHamCycles_eq`); the proof uses Mathlib's result that a connected graph with all degrees 2 is a single cycle. The homomorphism count equals the number of Mathlib homomorphisms $G \to_g H$ for simple $H$ (`numHom_simple`), and both permanents are stated with Mathlib's `Matrix.permanent`. The remaining definitions (the spectrum, the Potts counts, the Tutte polynomial, the seeds and the input codes) must be read by hand, as must Anthropic's model of computation and statement files.

**What is not formalized.** The numbered theorems, Lemma 4, the three counters of Section 2, the special cases (independent sets, the Max-Cut spectrum, the Ising model, the chromatic polynomial and $T(G; 0, 1-q)$) and the amplification of the one-sided error are Lean theorems; the proof sketches summarize the Lean proofs. Not formalized are the results we cite from the literature (lower bounds, earlier algorithms, Tutte's identity between $T(G; 0, 1-q)$ and nowhere-zero flows) and the novelty labels of Table 1.

**The reference implementation.** A Python package of about 2,100 lines mirrors every front end and post-step clause by clause, with the same variable indices and from the same input words as the Lean machines. Anthropic's counters are replaced by an exact DPLL counter with component caching that returns the weight enumerator of the solutions, so the implementation runs in exponential time; its purpose is to make the reductions concrete and testable. The tests compare every

algorithm with a direct enumeration of the quantity in the Lean statement (colorings, homomorphisms, assignments, covers, dominating sets, permutations, Hamiltonian cycles, connected vertex sets, connected dominating sets), check the shape bounds that the Lean proofs use, and measure the one-sided error of A5b, N2′ and N7′ over random seeds. A further test checks that the Python front ends are the Lean ones: a small Lean program evaluates the Lean definitions of all 18 front ends on 106 random input words, and the formulas agree clause for clause.

**Availability.** The Lean development, the Python package and the instructions to check both are at `https://github.com/ssenge/eth-corollaries`.

## 8 Limitations and conclusion

**What the theorems depend on.** Our results are Lean theorems; they do not assume an unproved hypothesis. They are exactly as sound as Lean's kernel and Anthropic's formalization, and they say what is intended only if Anthropic's statement files and the model of computation do. At the time of writing nobody has reviewed these statements independently, and the claimed refutations themselves are under review. The algorithms are galactic: no gain over $2^n$ is expected below $n \approx 10^{10}$.

**What the results show.** The variable count is the currency. $O(n)$ variables give $2^{\varepsilon n}$ for every $\varepsilon$; $n \cdot r(n)$ variables with $r = o(\sqrt{\lg n}/\lg\lg n)$ still give $2^{o(n)}$; for the uniform bound the clause width must stay below about $(\lg n)^{1/4}$. A sized counter makes the number of clauses irrelevant, which is why dense graphs are possible for N2, N2′, N7, N7′, A3 and A3′, and complement bits make it compatible with auxiliary variables.

**Open problems.** Colorings and homomorphisms into targets with $\lg h \geq (\lg n)^{1/6}$; #CNF-SAT of unbounded width with more clauses than in A1′; a deterministic version of N2′ and N7′, that is, deterministic Steiner tree, connected vertex cover and connected dominating set on dense graphs; the exact number of connected vertex sets of size $\ell$ on dense graphs, of which N2 gives the parity; a machine-checked algorithm for Hamiltonian cycle on graphs with $\omega(n\sqrt{\lg n})$ edges, where Tulsyan's written proof [25] reaches average degree $2^{o(\sqrt{\lg n})}$; the Tutte polynomial off the integer hyperbolas; permanents with larger integer entries; the matching polynomial of general graphs; and problems for which the refutations remove a lower bound but no reduction with few variables is known, such as dense Max-Cut, CNF-SAT with $\mathrm{poly}(n)$ clauses, planar problems below $2^{O(\sqrt{n})}$ and Subset Sum.

## Use of AI

Claude Opus 5.5 (Anthropic) was used throughout this research: to explore approaches, to develop and check proofs, to write the Lean formalization and the reference implementation, and to draft the text. All theorems were checked by Lean.

## References


[1] Anthropic. A $2^{o(n)}$ time algorithm for 3-SAT. Preprint hexagon:2610.00577v1, 26 October 2026.

[2] Anthropic. formal-math: Lean formalizations, subdirectory `eth`. `https://github.com/anthropics/formal-math`, 2026.

[3] C. Calabro. *The Exponential Complexity of Satisfiability Problems*. PhD thesis, UC San Diego, 2009.

[4] Y. Caro, D. B. West, and R. Yuster. Connected domination and spanning trees with many leaves. *SIAM J. Discrete Math.*, 13(2):202–211, 2000.

[5] L. Cai and D. Juedes. On the existence of subexponential parameterized algorithms. *J. Comput. System Sci.*, 67(4):789–807, 2003.

[6] C. Calabro, R. Impagliazzo, V. Kabanets, and R. Paturi. The complexity of Unique $k$-SAT: an isolation lemma for $k$-CNFs. *J. Comput. System Sci.*, 74(3):386–393, 2008.

[7] C. Calabro, R. Impagliazzo, and R. Paturi. A duality between clause width and clause density for SAT. In *CCC*, 2006.

[8] J. Chen, I. A. Kanj, and G. Xia. Improved upper bounds for vertex cover. *Theoret. Comput. Sci.*, 411(40–42):3736–3756, 2010.

[9] M. Cygan, F. V. Fomin, A. Golovnev, A. S. Kulikov, I. Mihajlin, J. Pachocki, and A. Socała. Tight lower bounds on graph embedding problems. *J. ACM*, 64(3):18, 2017.

[10] M. Cygan, J. Nederlof, M. Pilipczuk, M. Pilipczuk, J. M. M. van Rooij, and J. O. Wojtaszczyk. Solving connectivity problems parameterized by treewidth in single exponential time. In *FOCS*, 2011.

[11] M. de Berg and S. Kisfaludi-Bak. Lower bounds for dominating set in ball graphs and for weighted dominating set in unit-ball graphs. arXiv:2601.08425, 2026.

[12] F. Dehne, M. Fellows, H. Fernau, E. Prieto, and F. Rosamond. Nonblocker: parameterized algorithmics for minimum dominating set. In *SOFSEM*, LNCS 3831, 2006.

[13] H. Dell, T. Husfeldt, D. Marx, N. Taslaman, and M. Wahlén. Exponential time complexity of the permanent and the Tutte polynomial. *ACM Trans. Algorithms*, 10(4):21, 2014.

[14] C. M. Fortuin and P. W. Kasteleyn. On the random-cluster model I. Introduction and relation to other models. *Physica*, 57(4):536–564, 1972.

[15] R. Ganian, R. de Haan, I. Kanj, and S. Szeider. On existential MSO and its relation to ETH. In *MFCS*, LIPIcs 58:42, 2016.

[16] R. Impagliazzo and R. Paturi. On the complexity of $k$-SAT. *J. Comput. System Sci.*, 62(2):367–375, 2001.

[17] R. Impagliazzo, R. Paturi, and F. Zane. Which problems have strongly exponential complexity? *J. Comput. System Sci.*, 63(4):512–530, 2001.

[18] P. Jonsson, V. Lagerkvist, J. Schmidt, and H. Uppman. Relating the time complexity of optimization problems in light of the exponential-time hypothesis. In *MFCS*, LNCS 8635, pp. 408–419, 2014.

[19] The mathlib Community. The Lean mathematical library. In *CPP*, 2020.

[20] L. de Moura and S. Ullrich. The Lean 4 theorem prover and programming language. In *CADE*, LNCS 12699, 2021.

[21] OpenAI. The Exponential Time Hypothesis is false. Preprint, 17 October 2026, revised 25 October 2026. `https://github.com/openai/math`, family 378.

[22] O. Ore. *Theory of Graphs*. AMS Colloquium Publications 38, 1962.

[23] H. J. Ryser. *Combinatorial Mathematics*. Carus Mathematical Monographs 14, Mathematical Association of America, 1963.

[24] W. T. Tutte. A contribution to the theory of chromatic polynomials. *Canad. J. Math.*, 6:80–91, 1954.

[25] V. Tulsyan. Counting Hamiltonian cycles in sparse graphs in subexponential time, assuming the new #SAT algorithms. Preprint and Lean development, October 2026; versions of 28 and 29 October (commits ae323a3, ba4c161). `https://github.com/xennygrimmato/eth-hamiltonicity`.

[26] L. G. Valiant and V. V. Vazirani. NP is as easy as detecting unique solutions. *Theoret. Comput. Sci.*, 47:85–93, 1986.